SHORTBREAD

MAKES	ACTIVE TIME	REST	TOTAL TIME
1 dish, 15 by 25 cm, about 48 fingers of 5 cm by 12 mm	**20 min**	**chilled in the dish before the fingers come out**	**about 2 h**

OVEN
325F for about 30 min

INGREDIENTS

255 g	Unsalted butter, very soft
1/2 tsp	Salt
260 g	All-purpose flour
75 g	Cornstarch
70 g	Granulated sugar, for the dough
50 g	Superfine or granulated sugar, for the topping

METHOD

1. Heat the oven to 325F and butter a glass baking dish of 15 by 25 cm.
2. Put the butter in a mixing bowl. It needs to be very soft, somewhere around the consistency of mayonnaise or whipped cream.
3. Work the salt into the butter thoroughly.
4. Sift the flour and cornstarch together into a second bowl.
5. Tip the granulated sugar into the butter and stop mixing as soon as the two come together.
6. Add the sifted flour and cornstarch and mix just to a smooth dough, no further.
7. Pat the dough level into the dish. It should sit no deeper than 1.5 cm.
8. Bake about 30 minutes, until the top and the base are lightly browned. The middle stays pale.
9. Cool on a wire rack only until the slab is warm to the touch, not cold.
10. Scatter the superfine sugar over the surface. Tilt the dish so it coats the top evenly, then tip the surplus out.
11. Using a thin, very sharp knife, cut the slab into fingers roughly 12 mm wide and 5 cm long. This has to happen while it is still warm.
12. Chill the dish thoroughly, then lift the fingers out. The first one is awkward, after which a small thin offset spatula gets the rest out easily.

NOTES

The butter must be genuinely soft, at mayonnaise or whipped-cream consistency. A short burst in the microwave gets it there, or beat it on low in a metal bowl and warm the outside of the bowl with a kitchen torch.
75 g of cornstarch against 260 g of flour is what gives the sandy, short texture the cookie is named for. Rice flour is the traditional starch for the same job, and potato or tapioca starch also appear in older recipes.
Keep the slab under 1.5 cm deep, and let the centre stay pale while the top and base take colour.
Cut while the slab is still warm to the touch. Cold shortbread crumbles under the knife rather than slicing, so the chilling comes after the cutting, not before.
Airtight and somewhere cool, the fingers keep 2 weeks.

DATE ____ / ____ / ____ RATING ____ / 5 OVEN ADJ _____

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